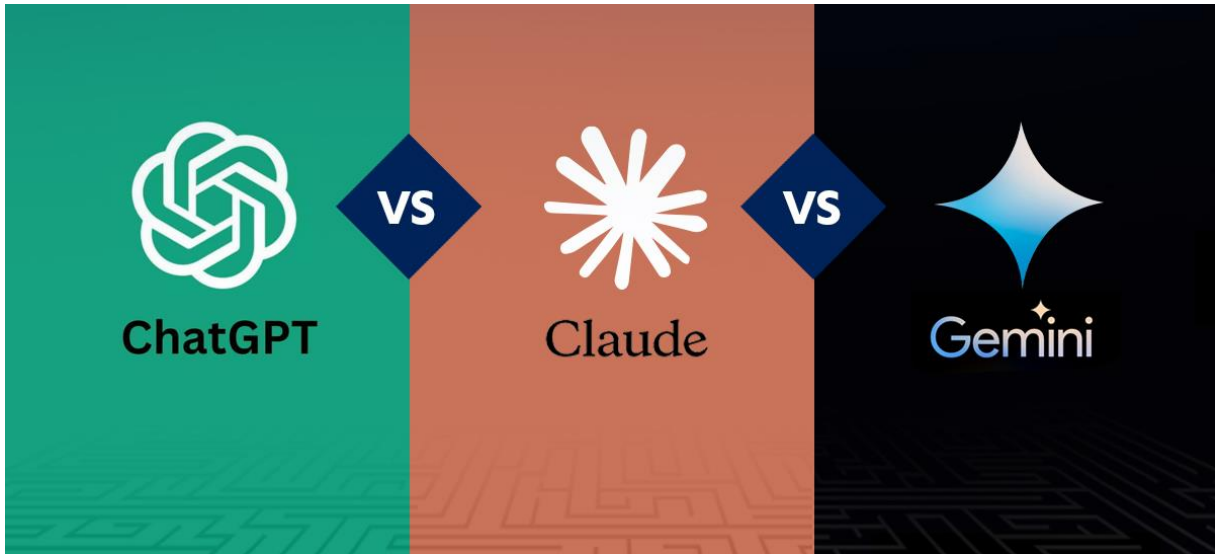


Zero-Shot vs Few-Shot Prompting

Task: Classifying Customer Support Messages



1. Objective

Compare a zero-shot prompt (instruction only) against a few-shot prompt (instruction + 3 labeled examples) for classifying 10 customer support messages as Complaint, Question, or Praise. The same 10 messages and both prompts were run across ChatGPT, Claude, and Gemini to see how much prompt structure affects accuracy and consistency.

2. The 10 Test Messages

Ground-truth labels (used to score accuracy) are shown in the third column. These were not included when the messages were shown to the models.

#	Message	Ground Truth
1	My order arrived late and the packaging was damaged. This is unacceptable!	Complaint
2	How do I reset my password? I keep getting an error.	Question
3	The product is exactly as described and works perfectly. Thank you!	Praise
4	I'm very disappointed with the customer service response time. No one replied for days.	Complaint
5	What are the return options if the item doesn't fit?	Question
6	Amazing support team! You solved my issue in minutes. Highly recommend.	Praise
7	The battery life is much worse than advertised. I want a refund.	Complaint
8	Can you tell me when the new version will be available?	Question
9	This is the best purchase I've made this year. Everything is top quality!	Praise
10	Your app keeps crashing on my phone. Fix this immediately.	Complaint

3. Zero-Shot Prompt

Instruction only — no examples given.

Classify the following customer support message into exactly one category: "Complaint", "Question", or "Praise".

Reply with only the category name for each message, one per line.

Messages:

1. "My order arrived late and the packaging was damaged. This is unacceptable!"
2. "How do I reset my password? I keep getting an error."
3. "The product is exactly as described and works perfectly. Thank you!"
4. "I'm very disappointed with the customer service response time. No one replied for days."
5. "What are the return options if the item doesn't fit?"
6. "Amazing support team! You solved my issue in minutes. Highly recommend."
7. "The battery life is much worse than advertised. I want a refund."
8. "Can you tell me when the new version will be available?"
9. "This is the best purchase I've made this year. Everything is top quality!"
10. "Your app keeps crashing on my phone. Fix this immediately."

4. Few-Shot Prompt

Instruction + 3 labeled examples before the same 10 messages.

You are an expert customer support classifier. Classify each message as exactly one of: "Complaint", "Question", or "Praise".

Here are examples:

Example 1:

Message: "The delivery was two weeks late and the item was broken."

Category: Complaint

Example 2:

Message: "What is the warranty period for this laptop?"

Category: Question

Example 3:

Message: "This is fantastic quality and arrived super fast. Great job!"

Category: Praise

Now classify the following messages. Reply with only the category name for each, one per line.

Messages:

1. "My order arrived late and the packaging was damaged. This is unacceptable!"
2. "How do I reset my password? I keep getting an error."
3. "The product is exactly as described and works perfectly. Thank you!"
4. "I'm very disappointed with the customer service response time. No one replied for days."
5. "What are the return options if the item doesn't fit?"
6. "Amazing support team! You solved my issue in minutes. Highly recommend."
7. "The battery life is much worse than advertised. I want a refund."
8. "Can you tell me when the new version will be available?"
9. "This is the best purchase I've made this year. Everything is top quality!"
10. "Your app keeps crashing on my phone. Fix this immediately."

Zero shot and few shot prompting method

This slide explains the two types of N-shot prompting, named zero-shot and few-shot prompting. The purpose of this slide is to represent the prompt input and model's response for both types with the help of a few input examples.

Zero-shot prompting

Overview	○ Refers to a scenario when predictions are produced without any explicit or supplemental examples ○ Excels at- ▪ Classification tasks like Sentiment analysis or spam detection ▪ Text transformation tasks like translation or summarization, and basic text synthesis ▪ Add text here
Prompt input	"What is the sentiment of the following sentence: 'I had a tiring day at the work'?"
Model's response	"The sentiment of the sentence is negative."

Few-shot prompting

Overview	○ Uses a small number of instances, often between two and five, to direct the model's output ○ Intended to point the model in the direction of higher performance when dealing with more context-specific issues ○ Allow the model to – ▪ More effectively tune its replies ▪ Improve the precision of its predictions by providing a snapshot of the intended outcome
Prompt input	Write a rhymed couplet about moonlight. Example 1: 'Under moonlight's gentle hue, Stars twinkle as the night imbues.' Example 2: 'Moonlit night, serene and still, Whispers secrets, nature's thrill.' Now, write a rhymed couplet about sunshine.
Model's response	'Sunshine dances, bright and clear, Chasing shadows, spreading cheer.'

5. Per-Message Results

Results below are real, from running the exact prompts in Sections 3 and 4 in ChatGPT, Claude, and Gemini.

[illegible]

6. Accuracy Summary

Tool	Zero-Shot Accuracy	Few-Shot Accuracy
ChatGPT	10 / 10	10 / 10
Claude	10 / 10	10 / 10
Gemini	10 / 10	10 / 10

7. Takeaway

All three tools scored 10/10 on both zero-shot and few-shot, so on this set of messages few-shot examples didn't add accuracy, every message carried an unambiguous emotional or lexical signal ('unacceptable,' 'thank you,' 'amazing,' 'fix this immediately'), which is exactly the kind of input all three models already handle reliably on instructions alone. That's a real finding, not a null result: it shows zero-shot prompting is sufficient once a task is well-specified and the inputs are clear-cut, and it isolates where prompting technique actually earns its keep ambiguous or borderline inputs (e.g. a frustrated message phrased as a question, or one that mixes praise with a complaint), inconsistent output formatting, and smaller or less capable models. To make the comparison more discriminating next time, the test set would need a few deliberately ambiguous messages, since a 10/10-vs-10/10 result mainly tells you the task was easy for frontier models, not that examples are unnecessary in general.